

Jean Rhys

Wide Sargasso Sea

Biography

- Born in 1890 in Dominica, British West Indies to Welsh doctor and Dominican Creole mother
- When she was sixteen, she was sent to England to her aunt and attended school there
- Influenced by modernist writer Ford Maddox Ford (stream of consciousness)
- Wrote about mistreated, rootless woman in her first novel "Voyage in the Dark"



- She disappeared from the public view
- *Wide Sargasso Sea* was published in 1966, which won her literary fame
- Rewriting of *JE* which she read in 1907
- "She seemed such a poor ghost, I thought I'd like to write her a life."
- Died in 1979 at the age of 87

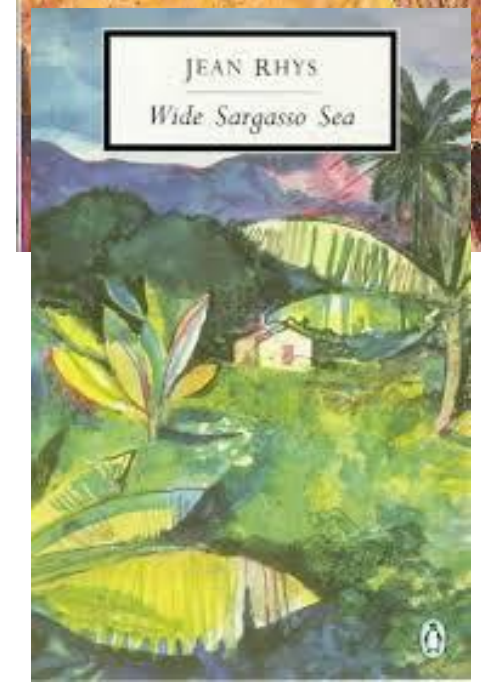
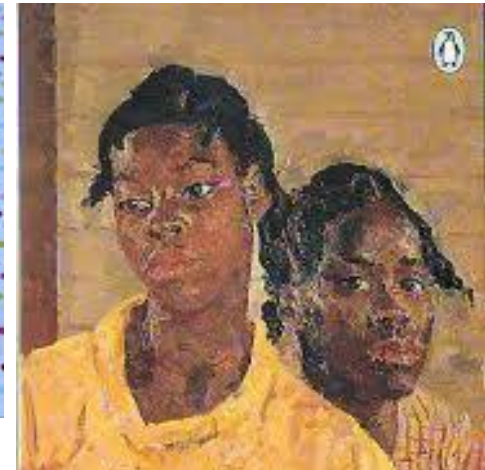


Rhy's identity

- "Do you consider yourself a **West Indian**?"
She shrugged. "It was such a long time ago when I left."
"So you don't think of yourself as a West Indian writer?"
Again she shrugged, but said nothing.
"What about **English**? Do you consider yourself an English writer?"
"No! I'm not, I'm not! I'm not even English."
"What about a **French** writer?" I asked.
Again she shrugged and said nothing.
"You have no desire to go back to **Dominica**?"
"Sometimes," she said.

Jean Rhys's reputation

- Modernist writer
- Caribbean writer from the post-colonial perspective
- Feminist writer against patriarchy





Title & significance



- Legendary murky body of water ocean (Bermuda Triangle) where ships become ensnared-space of danger and entrapment
- signaling the wide division between two worlds (Antoinette and Rochester/Europe and the Caribbean/sanity and madness)
- The entangled relationships of race and gender in the Caribbean area
- Mythic, mysterious in-between space-importance of language, obeah, folktales

Traditional realist novels (18th & 19th century novel) vs Modern novels (20th century~)

- Reality as knowable
- Truth as objective
- Belief in order and sequence
- Focus on individual's autonomy
- Traditional, stability, order
- Multiple, Unknowable, uncertain
 - Discontinuity and fragmentation
- Subjective (unreliable)
 - multiple points of view
- Time and space is collapsed, in flux, lack of causality
- Alienated, dislocated self
- Experimental, crisis, loss of faith

Modernist styles

- Rhys primarily uses stream of consciousness in the first person perspective with more fragmented, shifting, and unreliable narration
- Whereas Woolf uses fluid, omniscient stream of consciousness to dissolve the boundaries between character's inner lives and external events, Rhys stresses more dislocated, fractured identity and postcolonial tension
- Both challenge traditional realism, but Woolf focuses on psychological depth and radical interiority, whereas Rhys is political and revisionist, rewriting canonical authority of single perspective

Postcolonial approach

- Hybridity: any mixing of east and western culture
 - Racial hybridity: Creole (can be mixed blood or native white)
 - Literary hybridity: postcolonial writers attempt to 'write back' to the British canon (the western tradition) with revisionist adaption of classic works

- “The Creole in Charlotte Brontë’s novel is a lay figure—repulsive which does not matter, and not once alive which does. She is necessary to the plot, but always she shrieks, howls, laughs horribly, attacks all and sundry—off stage. For me (and for you I hope) she should be right on stage. She must be at least plausible with a past, the reason why Mr. Rochester treats her abominably and feels justified, even the reason why he thinks she is mad and why of course she goes mad...” (Rhys)
- “Of course Charlotte Brontë makes her own world, of course she convinces you, and that makes the poor Creole lunatic all the more dreadful. I remember being quite shocked, and when I re-read it rather annoyed. “That’s only one-side—the English side” sort of thing” (Rhys)

Significance of Rewriting

- Prequel of *JE* – it presents the madwoman's point of view
 - Insists on "speaking herself"
- Sympathetic history of the madman from her youth in the West Indies to the fire in Rochester's home
- Tells the untold stories of characters who are marginalized
- More rounded, psychologically nuanced treatment of Antoinette & Mr. Rochester
 - He becomes more interesting, equivocal figure
- Raises issues latent in *JE*:
 - the English fear and suspicion of foreigners
 - the evil of male economic and social domination

Form of Wide Sargasso Sea

- Stream of consciousness-follows the psychological process of the various speakers
- Multiple, limited, unreliable, shifting point of views
- Composed of 3 sections
 - 1st section: presents the mental processes of Antoinette in unfiltered and unmediated direct interior monologues – syntax and language show her simple and childlike nature
- The plot is open to multiple, contradictory interpretations-the reader struggles with the meaning and tries to judge the true state of the affair
- Different versions of events invite us to question the distinction between dream and reality, madness and sanity, truth and falsity

Historical setting

- Impoverished, fearful, isolated, Antoinette lives at Coulibri, the crumbling family estate near Spanish Town, Jamaica with her widowed mother and her sickly brother, Pierre
- Setting: Emancipation Act of 1834 which freed black slaves but no compensation
- complex shifting race relation with hostility and resentment
- great fear of violence from the newly freed blacks and expectation of economic ruin for the slave-powered sugar plantations

Theme of race

- “Marooned” – they are outcast from both the black and white communities (3)
 - Themes of enslavement – Antoinette and her mother entrapped
 - The Garden: paradise, Edenic setting but already corrupted & fallen “gone wild” (3)
 - How are different races portrayed? Who are seen as more sympathetic in the novel?
- “The people here hate us. They certainly hate me” (11)
- Does Rhys offer more than flat stereotypes of blacks?

Complexity of racial identity

Different racial groups or 'ranks' based on antagonism

- Blacks vs whites
 - Blacks vs Mixed blacks (Creole)
 - White English from England vs white slave owners in Jamaica (Creole)
 - Martinique (French) Creole vs British Jamaican Creole
- "None of you understand about us" (10)
- But this social hierarchy can be reversed (white nigger is lower than black nigger)

Other motifs

- Theme of enslavement
- Theme of isolation
- Theme of madness & insanity
- Theme of death (corruption, disease)
- Theme of superstition & magic

Theme of Identity

- How does Rhys characterize Antoinette?
- Antoinette's struggle to establish her identity, in relation to race, gender, and class
- Problem of self-representation of a female in a patriarchal society
- Women's dependence on men
- Like *JE*, it is a coming of age novel of unloved girl
- Antoinette's identity is fragile-insecure, fearful, fatalistic
- Has nightmares (8)

Annette

- Younger second wife to Mr. Cosway who drank to death and a womanizer with bastards (9)
- What leads to her madness?
- multiple alienations of the Creole
 - from the white people in the Spanish town because she is Creole, from Martinique and poor;
 - from the blacks because she is former slave-owner and poor
 - both Annette and Antoinette—seen as “white cockroaches” “white nigger”
 - Widowed-can only survive by marrying again

Christophine

- Antoinette's closest companion
- Surrogate mother – takes care of Antoinette instead of her mother who is indifferent "Oh let me alone" (4)
- Refuses to speak standard English & sings in patois (regional form of French)
- Loyal
- But feared for menacing power, tyrannical control (4)
- Obeah (10) a voodoo witch
- Antoinette's fear about the obeah

- England and the Caribbean are constantly opposed
- England is exotic fiction to Antoinette, just as non-European countries are seen as other, non-civilized, alien
- ie) The Miller's Daughter painting (30)

Tia

- “white cockroaches”- derogatory term for Creoles
- Tia and Antoinette’s friendship loses innocence when they start using racial stereotypes
- “cheating nigger” “white nigger” (7)
- wearing Tia’s dress is seen as “shameful... wild...worthless
- Her “nightmare” makes her feel paralyzed – she gets a new dress later and her mother remarries
- When she leaves the burning Coulibri, she gets hit by Tia “I will be like her... I saw myself. Like in a looking-glass” (19) - she serves as mirrors or doubles for Antoinette

Mr. Mason

- "he came to make money as they all do... one unfortunate's loss is always a clever man's gain" (10)
 - Temporarily improves the family fortunes
 - Mr. Mason's plan to import coolies causes the blacks revolt
 - ignorance about the history
 - racial stereotypes about the blacks of slaves of Jamaica
- "They're too damn lazy to be dangerous" (11)
- "They are children – they wouldn't hurt a fly." (13)

Language & Stories

- Language used to define, rename, and mark a character's place
- Shaping power of language-fictions can contribute to one's identity and one's understanding of reality

"I ran away and did not speak of it for I thought if I told no one it might not be true" (3)

- Rumor, gossip, lies, scandal can create fear and distrust as an actual threat

"They talk about us without stopping. They invent stories about you, and lies about me" (11)

- Jeane's obeah inspires fear more than through what it's rumored to do rather than through actual feats of magic
- Antoinette is destroyed by language-she cannot control the story told about her, as a "mad Creole woman"

Blacks rebellion

- The burning of the Coulibri house -parallel with Bertha's burning of Thornfield
 - Is it effective resistance against the system?
 - Parrot: clipped wings and copying human speech; its burning fall
 - blindly repeating words with no comprehension of their relation to oneself or the world
 - Symbol of Mimicry: members of a colonized society imitate the language, dress, politics, or cultural attitudes of their colonizers
 - ie) Antoinette mimics Englishness, imitating and behaving like one, but ultimately she is destroyed
- Pierre's death & Annette's breakdown

The Convent

- After being unconscious, Antoinette is sent to live with Aunt Cora in Spanish town
- Attends a convent school with different races- harassed by children and meets Sandi, her cousin "colored relative"
- She asserts her identity for the first time – "I will write my name in fire red, Antoinette Mason, née Cosway, Mount Calvary Convent, Spanish Town , Jamaica, 1839"
- Religious education but begins to question them
- Cultivation of female virtues of modesty and chastity
- "my refuge" (25) "I felt bolder, happier, more free. But not so safe." (26)
- Her second dream (27)
 - her beautiful long dress makes her fall
 - The ideal of femininity
 - Threat of the male
- Mr. Mason visits her for arrangement of her marriage